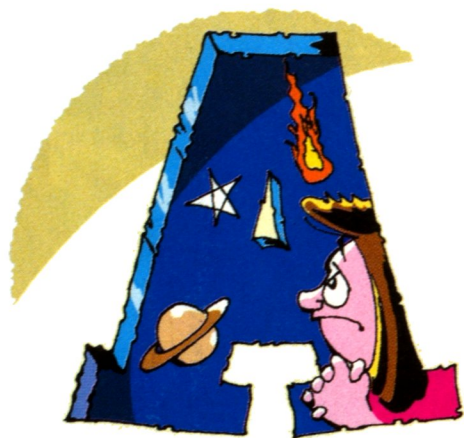




# The Alphabet of UNITY



SOME UNIQUE INDIANISMS IDENTIFY US AS ONE RACE, ONE PEOPLE, EVEN IF WE DO SPEAK IN A FEW THOUSAND DIFFERENT TONGUES

BY DILIP BOBB

Here's the rub. The last time a single party had a clear majority at the Centre was back in 1984. If the adult population of this country cannot agree on who should rule them, what does that say about a unified India? Then again, coalitions, with their motley mix of politicians from regional parties, do bring a pan-Indian flavour to Indian politics. Just how united are we as a nation? Not much, as any national survey will tell you—except when it comes to cricket and cinema—but there is an alphabet soup of oddities, personalities and characteristics that are common to all Indians, things that identify us all as one race, one people even if we speak in a few thousand different tongues. Here they are in alphabetical order.



**A** is for **Astrology**, an all-India obsession. Marriages, births, deaths, jobs, examinations, elections, selections are all governed by our unrestrained belief in the legion of astrologers who decide the fate of millions of lives every day. Never mind if they get it wrong, our faith in the position of the stars remains as unshaken as a bureaucrat's job.



**B** is for another kind of star, **Bachchan**, living proof of the efficacy of anti-ageing products. The Big B has captured the national psyche like no one else in Hindi cinema. The entire country prayed for his recovery after

